

UNITY CATALOG · GA JULY 2026

ALL OR NOTHING

Wrap several SQL statements in one transaction. They commit together or they roll back together.

```
BEGIN ATOMIC ... END;
```

THE PROBLEM

PROBLEM: 3 STATEMENTS, 3 SEPARATE COMMITS

1 `UPDATE accounts SET balance = balance - 100 WHERE id = 1;`
Account 1 is debited. Durable, on disk, irreversible.

COMMITTED

2 `UPDATE accounts SET balance = balance + 100 WHERE id = 2;`
Account 2 never receives it.

FAILED

3 `INSERT INTO transfer_log VALUES (1, 2, 100, now());`
No audit trail of any of it.

NEVER RAN



3 commits with different outcomes but all part of the same business transaction, so they should be coupled outcomes.

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THE FIX

WRAP THEM AND THEY MOVE AS ONE

○ ○ ○

```
1 BEGIN ATOMIC
2   UPDATE accounts SET balance = balance - 100.00 WHERE account_id = 1;
3   UPDATE accounts SET balance = balance + 100.00 WHERE account_id = 2;
4   INSERT INTO transfer_log
5     VALUES (1, 2, 100.00, current_timestamp());
6 END;
7
8 -- Two tables. One commit. One Delta log entry.
```

 UC MANAGED TABLES

 CATALOG COMMITS ON

 DBR 18.0+ OR SQL WAREHOUSE

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THE PROOF

THE LAST STATEMENT FAILS. WATCH THE FIRST TWO VANISH.

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```
1 BEGIN ATOMIC
2   -- These two succeed...
3   INSERT INTO transfer_log VALUES (2, 1, 5000.00, now());
4   UPDATE accounts SET balance = balance + 5000.00 WHERE account_id = 1;
5
6   -- ...then this trips CHECK (balance ≥ 0)
7   UPDATE accounts SET balance = balance - 5000.00 WHERE account_id = 2;
8 END;
```

ACCOUNT 1 BALANCE

400.00

Credit undone

LOG ROWS

1

Insert undone

DELTA COMMITS

0

Nothing written

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THE RULES

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SIX THINGS TO GET RIGHT



Turn on catalog commits

`delta.feature.catalogManaged = 'supported'` on every table you write to.



No DDL inside

CREATE, ALTER and DROP run outside the transaction. So does time travel.



Prefer BEGIN ATOMIC

Row-level conflict detection and automatic rollback. No open session to leak.



Build retry logic

Commits are optimistic. Conflicts surface at commit time and the loser fails.



Reads are repeatable

First touch pins a snapshot. Later reads ignore everyone else's commits.



Know the ceilings

100 tables per transaction. Everything rolls back after 48 hours.

STOP REPAIRING HALF-WRITTEN DATA

BEGIN ATOMIC ... END;

Full walkthrough → dailydatabricks.tips/s/transactions

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